Decathlon — Deep Research Report

Prepared for: Head of Technology, market level

Contents

1. Company at a glance

Decathlon is a French sporting goods group founded in 1976 by Michel Leclercq and headquartered at Villeneuve-d'Ascq, near Lille. It designs, manufactures and sells its own equipment and apparel through a vertically integrated model, which gives it data across the whole chain from design through manufacturing to point of sale — a position few competitors hold. The group is privately held, controlled by the Mulliez family alongside the founding Leclercq family, with a substantial employee shareholding: the company reports 52,491 teammates holding shares, around 51% of the workforce.

The 2025 results, published on 2 April 2026, put gross merchandise volume at €20.7 billion, up 7.1% in local currencies, and net sales at €16.8 billion, up 5.6% in local currencies and 4.0% after currency effects. EBITDA rose 21% to €1.8 billion and net income 16% to €910 million. The group ended the year with 1,902 stores across 82 countries and regions, employing 102,913 people, and sold 1.23 billion products. Digital sales — e-commerce, connected orders placed in stores, and external marketplaces — accounted for 20.2% of the total.

Governance changed during 2025. Javier López, previously global chief value chain officer and before that head of the German and Spanish regions, became chief executive, succeeding Barbara Martin Coppola. Julien Leclercq was appointed Chairman of the Board. López has framed the company around a 2030 goal of positively affecting one billion people, and 2026 is Decathlon's 50th anniversary year.

Expansion is running through channels Decathlon does not fully control. In Germany, where it passed 100 stores in late 2025 and now runs around 105 against a target of at least 150 by end 2027, it opened a roughly 1,000 square metre concession inside MediaMarkt's Perlach centre in Munich on 26 March 2026 under MediaMarktSaturn's Space-as-a-Service arrangement, with more to follow, plus store-in-stores in Galeria department stores. In Spain, the competition authority approved Decathlon's acquisition of 18 Intersport stores in July 2026 with conditions attached. Decathlon Pulse, the group's investment arm and startup studio, has deployed around €400 million since 2018 across AllTricks, Bergfreunde, Recyc'Elit, Rebike Mobility and Bikeleasing Group.

Questions to ask on the day:

- How much of your market's growth is coming through concessions, acquisitions and partner formats rather than owned stores?
- What does a MediaMarkt concession or an acquired Intersport store actually need from you technically, and how long does it take?
- Where does your market sit against the group's 20.2% digital share?

2. Strategic direction

The strategic centre of gravity is the integrated model itself. Decathlon's 2025 statement is explicit that combining design, production and distribution is what lets it hold value-for-money at scale, and the 2025 profitability jump — EBITDA up 21% on net sales up 4% — is the evidence being used to defend that position internally. For a technology function, this matters because the systems estate has to span product development, manufacturing and retail rather than just retail.

Circularity has moved from initiative to core product strategy. Ecodesigned products accounted for 53.9% of sales in 2025, which the company describes as sustainable design becoming the primary engine of its product strategy rather than a niche. Repair workshops now operate in almost every store worldwide, 1,746 of them, and 1.58 million second-hand products were sold across 43 markets. Decathlon Digital has publicly stated an ambition of €1 billion in circular sales. Each of those — repair, resale, rental — is a distinct transaction type with its own data, pricing and traceability requirements.

Cycling and mobility are the clearest category bet. Decathlon took ownership of the Decathlon CMA CGM cycling team, acquired roughly 65% of Bikeleasing Group at a reported enterprise value of €525 million, closing in the first half of 2026, and took a majority stake in Rebike Mobility in January 2026 with more than €10 million of fresh capital, expanding Rebike's shop-in-shop presence to over ten Decathlon stores. Bikeleasing brings around 81,000 corporate customers representing some 3.9 million employees — a B2B relationship model quite unlike Decathlon's retail base.

Decarbonisation continues to be tracked against growth. Absolute carbon emissions are down 16% since 2021, the fourth consecutive year of decoupling, with 89.4% of electricity consumed from renewable sources and on-site coal use ended among tier 1 and tier 2 suppliers.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which of the circular services — repair, resale, rental — is hardest to support in your market and why?
- Bikeleasing brings a corporate B2B model into the group. Does that land on your systems or stay separate?
- What does the 50th anniversary year mean in practice for the technology roadmap?

3. Industry forces

The sporting goods market has turned harder during 2026, and the pressure is showing on the largest players rather than the value end. Nike expects sales to decline in the second half of 2026 and has restructured around vertical sport teams, moving roughly 8,000 people into smaller cross-functional groups. Dick's Sporting Goods and Foot Locker, together operating around 3,100 stores, reported weaker-than-expected results in August 2026 with a notably dim outlook. Decathlon's growth in that context is not the sector rising.

Tariffs and sourcing remain the dominant supply-side issue. Duties rose sharply through 2025 and remain well above historical levels, driving a rebalancing of manufacturing footprints away from China and, in footwear, out of concentrated exposure to Vietnam toward India and Indonesia. Sporting goods executives interviewed by McKinsey cite automation and digitalisation as the main levers for cutting lead times and protecting margin — which places the burden squarely on the technology and supply chain functions rather than on merchandising.

Physical inactivity is the structural backdrop. Pooled analysis published in The Lancet Global Health in 2024 found insufficient physical activity rising among adults worldwide. For Decathlon that is simultaneously a constrained core market and the justification for the 2030 one-billion-people ambition, which pushes toward beginner-level products, accessible pricing and services rather than premium performance gear.

Channel convergence is accelerating in ways that create integration work. Decathlon selling inside MediaMarkt stores, and MediaMarktSaturn sub-letting space as a service, is one instance of a broader pattern in which retail space, catalogue and fulfilment are being unbundled and recombined between companies that were not previously partners.

Questions to ask on the day:

- How much tariff and sourcing volatility reaches your systems as a change request rather than staying in supply chain?
- Is the beginner-and-accessibility positioning changing what your market's digital experience has to do?

4. Regulatory and compliance frame

Product safety obligations tightened with the EU General Product Safety Regulation, applicable since December 2024, which extends risk assessment, traceability and recall duties across all consumer goods including online sales and requires a responsible person established in the EU for products placed on the market. For a vertically integrated retailer selling tens of thousands of own-brand references, this is largely a data and traceability problem rather than a legal one: the obligations only work if product records, supplier records and sales records can be tied together on demand.

Sustainability reporting is the larger programme. Decathlon states that it is transitioning during 2026 from Non-Financial Reporting Directive reporting to a voluntary ESG report, explicitly as a preparatory step toward full Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive compliance for the 2027 financial year. The Omnibus I Directive, in force since 18 March 2026, raised CSRD thresholds to companies with more than 1,000 employees and more than €450 million net turnover and pushed application to financial years beginning on or after 1 January 2027; Decathlon sits far above both thresholds, so the narrowing of scope that removed most mid-market companies does not apply. The practical consequence is a hard deadline for auditable environmental and value-chain data.

France's duty of vigilance law requires large companies to publish a plan identifying and addressing human rights and environmental risks across the value chain, and Decathlon publishes both a vigilance plan and a modern slavery statement annually. Both depend on supplier data collected across a manufacturing footprint spread over multiple countries.

Questions to ask on the day:

- What does CSRD readiness for FY2027 require from your market specifically, and who is collecting it?
- Where does product traceability data currently break between manufacturing and retail?
- Which compliance obligations still land on your team as manual extraction requests?

5. The technology leader's world at Decathlon

Technology at Decathlon is organised through Decathlon Digital, a unit of roughly 1,500 people spread across Europe, Asia and North America, building software, data, security and robotics for the group. Fouad Latrech is Global Chief Technology Officer, having joined in 2019 as e-commerce CTO from a background in financial services at BNP Paribas, ING France and Orange Bank before moving into the global role. His published remit covers software engineering for all business sectors and corporate functions plus cloud platform engineering across around 65 countries. He has spoken publicly about the formative experience of stabilising e-commerce infrastructure under the pandemic traffic surge, and about cyber risk, compliance and governance as the recurring international challenges.

That structure defines the shape of a market-level technology role. It is not a standalone IT department; it is a local node in a global engineering organisation, which means the job is as much about influence, sequencing and translation as about building. Decathlon has publicly described its data approach as distributed, with entities owning their own data while a global view is maintained — an arrangement that gives a market genuine autonomy and genuine obligation at the same time. The consequence is that the questions that matter locally are usually about what to adopt, what to adapt and what to escalate, rather than what to build from scratch.

The catalogue is one concrete illustration of scale. Decathlon's 100th German store, opened in Nuremberg in late 2025, gives customers access to 36,000 own-brand products and more than

250,000 marketplace items through in-store digital terminals. The sellable assortment inside a physical store is now several times the physical assortment, and most of it is third-party. Every one of those references needs accurate attributes, availability and pricing to be useful at the moment a customer is standing in front of a screen.

Decathlon has also been an early and visible adopter on the customer-facing side, including an application developed jointly with Apple for Vision Pro, discussed publicly by Latrech in 2024. The pattern across public statements is consistent: build capability in-house, spread it across markets, and keep the data inside the group.

Questions to ask on the day:

- What decisions genuinely sit with you locally, and which have to go to the global organisation?
- How does your market get onto the global roadmap when it needs something that only affects you?
- What is the local team accountable for that global engineering cannot see?
- Where do you spend most of your time — adapting global products, running local operations, or arguing for priority?

6. Peer signals

Decathlon's own scale is the first useful benchmark. In the NRF and Kantar Top 50 Global Retailers published in April 2026, which measures international direct selling, Decathlon placed 33rd with $17 billion in revenues and 1,853 stores — the highest-ranked sporting goods retailer. JD Sports came in at 37th with $14 billion and 6,004 stores, a much larger network generating less revenue, which is a different theory of what a sports retail estate is for.

MediaMarktSaturn is simultaneously a partner and a signal. Its Space-as-a-Service strategy sub-lets floor space to complementary retailers, with Decathlon now among them in Germany. Separately it has opened its in-store retail media inventory to programmatic booking through One Tech Group, rolling out across European markets during 2026. Both moves treat the store as a platform to be monetised by third parties rather than purely as a place to sell own stock — a direction that has clear implications for who integrates with whom.

The US specialists are the cautionary case. Dick's Sporting Goods and Foot Locker, which between them run around 3,100 stores, cut guidance in August 2026, with Dick's shares falling more than 27% in a single session. Nike, meanwhile, has reorganised around vertical sport teams to shorten decision cycles. The common thread is that scale and omnichannel maturity have not insulated anyone from a demand downturn, which strengthens the argument for cost discipline in technology investment rather than weakening it.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Is the store-as-platform model something Decathlon is considering, and would that land on your market first?
- Which peers does the group actually benchmark technology against, and does that list match yours?

7. Friction map

The dominant tension for a market-level technology lead in this organisation is autonomy against alignment. A distributed model gives a market the ability to move on its own data and its own priorities, but the platforms, the standards and most of the engineering capacity sit globally across 65 countries. Local needs that are genuinely local are the hardest to fund, because they benefit one market and cost the global roadmap.

The second is that the estate is becoming heterogeneous faster than it is becoming standardised. Owned stores, MediaMarkt concessions, Galeria store-in-stores, Rebike shop-in-shops and acquired Intersport locations in Spain are five different integration problems, each with someone else's building, systems or commercial terms attached. Growth by partnership is faster commercially and slower technically.

Third, the catalogue has outgrown the store. When an in-store terminal exposes 36,000 own-brand references alongside more than 250,000 marketplace items, product data quality stops being a back-office concern and becomes the in-store experience. Availability, attributes and pricing all have to be right at the moment of the conversation.

Fourth, the circular services multiply transaction types. Repair across 1,746 workshops, second-hand across 43 markets, and now bike leasing with a corporate B2B customer base each involve records that outlive the original sale — service histories, ownership transfers, refurbishment states. Systems designed around a single point-of-sale event handle these badly.

Fifth, CSRD readiness for FY2027 imposes a fixed date on data that currently sits in many places. Unlike most technology work, it cannot be resequenced.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which of these is actually your problem this quarter, and which belongs to someone else?
- What would you fix first if the global roadmap gave you one slot?

Challenge cards

Card 1 of 2

Title: Growth in someone else's building

The challenge: The fastest route to new stores is increasingly a concession, a store-in-store or an acquisition — space and sometimes systems that belong to another company. Each arrival is a distinct integration problem, and the commercial deal is typically done before the technical work is scoped.

Who feels it: Market technology leadership, store operations, and the expansion teams whose timelines assume the systems will simply be there.

Why it persists: The commercial logic is strong and the speed is real. Decathlon Germany's expansion director put it plainly to Handelsblatt: locations that classic branch expansion would have reached in four years are available immediately through MediaMarktSaturn. That argument wins, and it should. But no two partner formats present the same technical surface, and there is no standard template for a store that is inside another retailer's estate.

What solved looks like: A repeatable integration pattern for non-owned formats — point of sale, inventory visibility, customer identity, payment — that can be applied in weeks rather than negotiated each time, and that expansion teams can factor into their timelines before the deal closes.

Evidence base: Decathlon opened a roughly 1,000 square metre concession inside MediaMarkt Perlach in Munich on 26 March 2026 under MediaMarktSaturn's Space-as-a-Service arrangement, with further locations planned; it also operates store-in-stores in Galeria, has expanded Rebike shop-in-shops to over ten of its own stores, and received conditional Spanish approval in July 2026 to acquire 18 Intersport stores.

Open question: How many distinct store-format integration patterns is your market currently supporting, and which of them would you retire if you could?

Card 2 of 2

Title: The catalogue is bigger than the store

The challenge: A customer standing at an in-store terminal can reach several times more products than are physically on the shelves, most of them from third parties. The quality of that experience depends entirely on product data that the store team neither creates nor controls.

Who feels it: Store teams answering questions they cannot verify, market technology leadership owning the terminal experience, and the customer who ordered something that turns out not to be available as described.

Why it persists: Own-brand data comes from Decathlon's own design and manufacturing chain; marketplace data comes from sellers at very different levels of discipline. Bringing them to a common standard means either constraining who can sell or investing continuously in enrichment and validation. Both are expensive, and the assortment keeps growing.

What solved looks like: Consistent, trustworthy attributes, availability and pricing across own-brand and marketplace items, so a store associate can use the terminal in front of a customer with the same confidence they have picking a product off the shelf.

Evidence base: Decathlon's 100th German store, opened in Nuremberg in late 2025, offers access to 36,000 own-brand products and more than 250,000 marketplace items through in-store digital terminals. Group-wide, marketplaces form part of the 20.2% digital sales share reported for 2025.

Open question: What proportion of terminal sessions end without a transaction, and do you know whether data quality is the reason?

Where this document is thin

- No technology budget, headcount or run-versus-change split is public for Decathlon Digital or for any individual market.
- The market-level technology role's reporting line, mandate and KPIs are not documented publicly.
- Current holders of the Chief Digital Officer and AI leadership roles should be confirmed directly; public appointment reporting for those posts predates the last eighteen months.
- The core platform estate — ERP, point of sale, order management, cloud providers, marketplace platform — is not described in any current public source.
- Decathlon's data governance model is described publicly only in general terms; how much authority actually sits with a market is unclear.
- No public breakdown exists of digital sales share by market, so the 20.2% group figure may not reflect your market at all.
- The technical arrangements behind the MediaMarktSaturn concessions and the Spanish Intersport acquisition have not been described.
- No recent public information covers Decathlon's security posture, incident history or governance.

- Whether Bikeleasing and Rebike will be integrated into group systems or run independently is not stated.
- The 2025 non-financial figures were published as still being audited, so environmental and workforce numbers may be restated.